SURAT
SHARIFA WAHAAB, 75
Family matriarch

The con:
Data leak from Aadhaar website
Sum lost:
Rs 20 lakh

"I was certain they were real"

Sharifa Wahaab had always been the formidable matriarch of her sprawling Surat family—a clan of children, grandchildren and extended kin who orbited her with a mix of awe and reverence. But on an ordinary morning, her fortress of certitude began to crumble.

The call came like a shot in the dark. A cold, disembodied voice informed her that her phone number had surfaced in a phishing scam linked to a "data leak from the Aadhaar website". The threat was clear: she was about to be raided by the CBI. In her seven decades, Sharifa had never known fear like this.

But the raid didn't happen. Instead, the callers imposed a sinister condition: she was under "digital arrest", forbidden from telling anyone about the ongoing investigation. Any deviation would bring "consequences".

For seven excruciating days, Sharifa kept her phone camera on, moving through her daily routine with a shadowy pair of eyes constantly following her. "A man in uniform spoke to me briefly on camera," she recounted later. "The others were in plain clothes, but their voices... it carried an authority I could not question. They made me feel like I was guilty of something unspeakable."

Meanwhile, a woman entered the charade, her tone softer, more understanding. She planted the idea that this might all be a tragic misunderstanding. By the sixth day, the ultimatum came: if Sharifa wanted to avoid immediate interrogation, she could provide a "surety bond" of Rs 70 lakh. The money would prove her willingness to cooperate, and if the investigation exonerated her, it would be returned. "I was certain these were real officers, so my money was safe. All I wanted was for it to end," she would later tell investigators. The next day, she transferred Rs 20 lakh from her own accounts, believing she was buying her freedom. The digital arrest was momentarily lifted, but the warning lingered: if the remaining balance wasn't paid within 72 hours, there would be "visitors". Sharifa, desperate, turned to the family's investment consultant to liquidate her mutual funds.

It was then that the web of lies began to unravel. The alarmed consultant contacted Sharifa's son—a 45-year-old international diamond trader. When he confronted his mother, she broke down. The money, moved via a series of "mule accounts", was already gone. "She refused to believe it was a scam," an investigating officer recounts. "When the reality sank in, she had a nervous breakdown." Says her son, "Even now she flinches when her phone rings."

"Their voices... it carried an authority I could not question. They made me feel like I was guilty of something unspeakable"

-Jumana Shah

a complaint. By this time, the money has gone through several layers of laundering.

The Gujarat investigation, which saw the arrest of 17 Indians and four Taiwanese nationals, has found that the latter were earning Rs 1-2 crore per day and were planning to recruit more local agents to expand their network and generate up to Rs 10 crore daily. And though local arrests have been made, the foreign masterminds remain elusive. The Indian operators often have no direct connection to the overseas syndicates, acting only as middlemen to ensure the smooth functioning of mule accounts and financial gateways.

Police investigations have also uncovered shocking details about the involvement of bank insiders. For instance, in Puri's case, the money swindled from him was funnelled through more than 70 accounts, including one in the name of one Suman Rani at HDFC Bank's Rupana branch in Muktsar, Punjab. Suman admitted she opened the account remotely for Rs 5,000. Branch manager Preet Indra facilitated the fraudulent account opening. Another accomplice, Mukesh, withdrew money using cheques from the account, and was in constant contact with her.

Many cybersecurity experts point to vulnerabilities even within the RBI's financial system. Bank employees on short-term contracts or outsourced KYC (Know Your Customer) agents have access to sensitive data, which they sell or misuse. Some banks, especially their smaller branches, operate with outdated software and lax internal controls, making it easier for employees to manipulate systems without detection. "Compared with the US, digital banking in India is somewhat compromised on data privacy," says Florida-based Pankaj Ojha, director, Deutsche Bank. "In a banking system, the regulator plays a crucial role by forcing banks to plug loopholes."